The Role of Motivation in Adopting Ethical Human Values

Universal Human Values (UHV) — Individual Assignment | Course Outcome: CO1

Name of Student:	**SREE HARI S**	Roll Number:	**25EC016**
Programme / Branch:	**B.E./B.Tech, ECE (Electronics & Communication Engineering)**	Semester:	**2**
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1. Introduction

Ethical human values — such as honesty, trust, respect, care, and justice — are widely acknowledged as essential for a fulfilling personal life and a harmonious society. Yet knowledge of these values alone does not guarantee that a person will actually live by them. A student may be taught, in theory, that honesty is important, and may even agree with the idea, but still act dishonestly under pressure or temptation. This gap between knowing a value and living it points to the central importance of motivation. Motivation is the internal driving force that moves a person from mere intellectual acceptance of a value to its consistent practice in thought, behaviour, and work. This assignment examines what motivation means in the context of Universal Human Values (UHV), why it is necessary for the genuine adoption of ethical values, the sources from which such motivation can arise, and the practical implications of this understanding for engineering students and professionals.

2. Understanding Motivation in the Context of Human Values

In ordinary usage, motivation refers to the reason or driving force behind a particular action. In the framework of Universal Human Values, motivation is understood more specifically as the inner conviction that arises when a person verifies a value through their own self-exploration and finds it to be true to their own natural acceptance, rather than something imposed from outside as a rule, reward, or fear of punishment. There is an important distinction here between two kinds of motivation:

2.1 External or Imposed Motivation

This form of motivation comes from outside the individual — for example, following ethical conduct because of fear of law, fear of social disapproval, desire for reward, or pressure from parents, teachers, or an organisation. While such motivation can produce correct behaviour for a period of time, it tends to be unstable. As soon as external monitoring is removed, the behaviour is likely to change, because the person never actually owned the value; they only complied with it.

2.2 Internal or Self-Verified Motivation

This form of motivation arises when a person, through the process of self-exploration, examines a value against their own natural acceptance and finds that living by it genuinely leads to happiness, harmony, and the fulfilment of their basic human aspirations. Once a value is verified in this manner, following it is no longer experienced as a burden or an external rule; it becomes a natural expression of the person's own understanding. This is the kind of motivation that UHV aims to cultivate, because it is durable and does not depend on supervision, reward, or fear.

Aspect	External (Imposed) Motivation	Internal (Self-Verified) Motivation
Source	Fear, reward, rules, social pressure	Self-exploration and natural acceptance
Stability	Weak; depends on supervision	Strong; independent of supervision
Effect on the person	Compliance, possible inner conflict	Conviction, inner harmony
Durability	Short-term	Long-term / lifelong

3. Why Motivation Is Necessary for Adopting Ethical Values

Several reasons explain why motivation, and not information alone, is the deciding factor in whether a person actually lives by ethical human values:

Bridging the knowing–doing gap: A person may intellectually accept that honesty or cooperation is good, but without the inner conviction that this is true and beneficial for them, this knowledge remains theoretical. Motivation converts understanding into consistent action.

Sustaining behaviour under pressure: Ethical choices are tested most severely in situations of temptation, competition, or difficulty. Values adopted only because of external rules tend to collapse under such pressure, whereas self-verified motivation continues to guide behaviour because the person is convinced of its worth.

Reducing inner conflict: When a person acts ethically only due to fear or social expectation while privately doubting its value, an inner contradiction develops between what they do and what they actually believe. Motivation rooted in self-exploration resolves this contradiction and produces a state of inner harmony.

Making ethics self-sustaining rather than policed: A society or profession that depends entirely on rules, audits, and punishments to enforce ethical conduct will always have gaps, because it is impossible to monitor every action. Intrinsically motivated individuals carry ethical values into every situation, including those where no one is watching.

Enabling long-term commitment: Skills and technical competence can be acquired relatively quickly, but ethical conduct needs to be sustained over an entire career and life. Only a value that a person is genuinely motivated to uphold can survive this long

span of time and changing circumstances.

4. Sources of Motivation for Ethical Human Values

Motivation to adopt ethical values can arise from several interconnected sources, which UHV encourages students to examine critically rather than accept blindly:

Self-exploration: Reflective inquiry into what one truly wants — continuous happiness and prosperity — and an honest examination of whether dishonest or self-centred behaviour actually delivers these outcomes. This process of verification, rather than instruction, is considered the most reliable source of lasting motivation in the UHV framework.

Natural acceptance: Every human being has an inner sense of what feels right, prior to conditioning by society. When a person notices that values such as trust and respect feel naturally acceptable to them (they would want to be trusted and respected by others), this recognition itself becomes a source of motivation to extend the same values to others.

Observation of consequences: Reflecting on real experiences — one's own or those of others — where dishonest or unethical action led to broken relationships, stress, or loss of self-respect, while ethical conduct led to trust and peace of mind, strengthens the motivation to choose the ethical path.

Role models and mentors: Teachers, family members, and respected professionals who consistently practise ethical values can inspire students to see that such values are livable and worthwhile, adding to their own motivation.

Institutional and curricular support: Structured exposure through courses such as UHV, guided self-reflection exercises, and discussion-based classroom sessions give students a systematic opportunity to examine and strengthen their motivation, rather than leaving it to chance.

5. Relevance for Engineering Students and Professionals

For engineering students in particular, this understanding of motivation has direct practical significance. Engineers routinely make decisions that affect public safety, resource use, and organisational trust — such as reporting test results honestly, maintaining quality standards even when cutting corners would be cheaper, or protecting user data responsibly. A professional who follows ethical codes only because of the fear of an audit or a penalty clause is vulnerable to lapses whenever oversight is weak. In contrast, an engineer who is internally motivated because they have reflected on and accepted the value of trust, competence, and responsibility is far more likely to sustain ethical conduct across their career, including in high-pressure situations where no external authority is directly checking their work. This is precisely why technical curricula increasingly include a value education component: not to add another rule to memorise, but to give students the opportunity to develop self-verified motivation for ethical conduct before they enter

professional life.

5.1 Illustrative Example

Consider two engineering interns asked to test a batch of components before dispatch. The first intern reports the results accurately only because they know their supervisor cross-checks a sample of reports — their compliance is externally motivated. If the checking process is ever relaxed, the temptation to skip tests or adjust figures to save time increases. The second intern reports results accurately because they have reflected on the value of trust and recognised that inaccurate reporting could endanger users and damage the trust their team places in them — a motivation that is self-verified. This intern continues to report honestly even when no one is checking, because the value has become their own conviction rather than an imposed rule. This simple comparison illustrates why UHV places such strong emphasis on cultivating internal motivation rather than relying on external enforcement alone.

6. Personal Reflection

Reflecting on my own experience as an engineering student, I notice that values such as honesty in academic work and respect for teammates feel most stable when I have genuinely thought through why they matter to me — for instance, recognising that I would want others to be honest with me, and that copied or dishonest work ultimately undermines my own learning and self-respect. In situations where I have followed a rule only because it was enforced (such as a submission guideline), my commitment to it was noticeably weaker than in situations where I understood and accepted the reasoning behind it. This suggests that building the habit of self-exploration — pausing to ask whether a value is something I genuinely accept, rather than something I am merely told to follow — is a practical starting point for developing the kind of lasting, self-verified motivation that this assignment has discussed.

7. Conclusion

Motivation is the link between merely knowing about ethical human values and actually living by them. While externally imposed motivation — driven by fear, reward, or social pressure — can produce short-term compliance, it is inherently fragile and collapses once external pressure is removed. Lasting ethical conduct instead depends on internal, self-verified motivation, developed through honest self-exploration, reflection on natural acceptance, and observation of real consequences. For students and future professionals, cultivating this kind of motivation is not a one-time exercise but an ongoing process of self-examination. It is this inner conviction, rather than any external rule alone, that ultimately ensures ethical human values are adopted genuinely and practised consistently, both in personal life and in professional conduct.

8. References

[1] R. R. Gaur, R. Sangal, and G. P. Bagaria, *A Foundation Course in Human Values and Professional Ethics*, 2nd ed. New Delhi, India: Excel Books, 2019.

[2] AICTE Model Curriculum, *Universal Human Values (UHV) II: Understanding Harmony*, All India Council for Technical Education, New Delhi, 2018.

[3] R. R. Gaur, R. Asthana, and G. P. Bagaria, *Teachers' Manual for A Foundation Course in Human Values and Professional Ethics*, New Delhi, India: Excel Books, 2010.

[4] UNESCO, *Learning to Live Together: Education Policies and Realities in the Asia-Pacific*, Bangkok: UNESCO Bangkok, 2014. (Referenced for the general discussion on value education in curricula.)